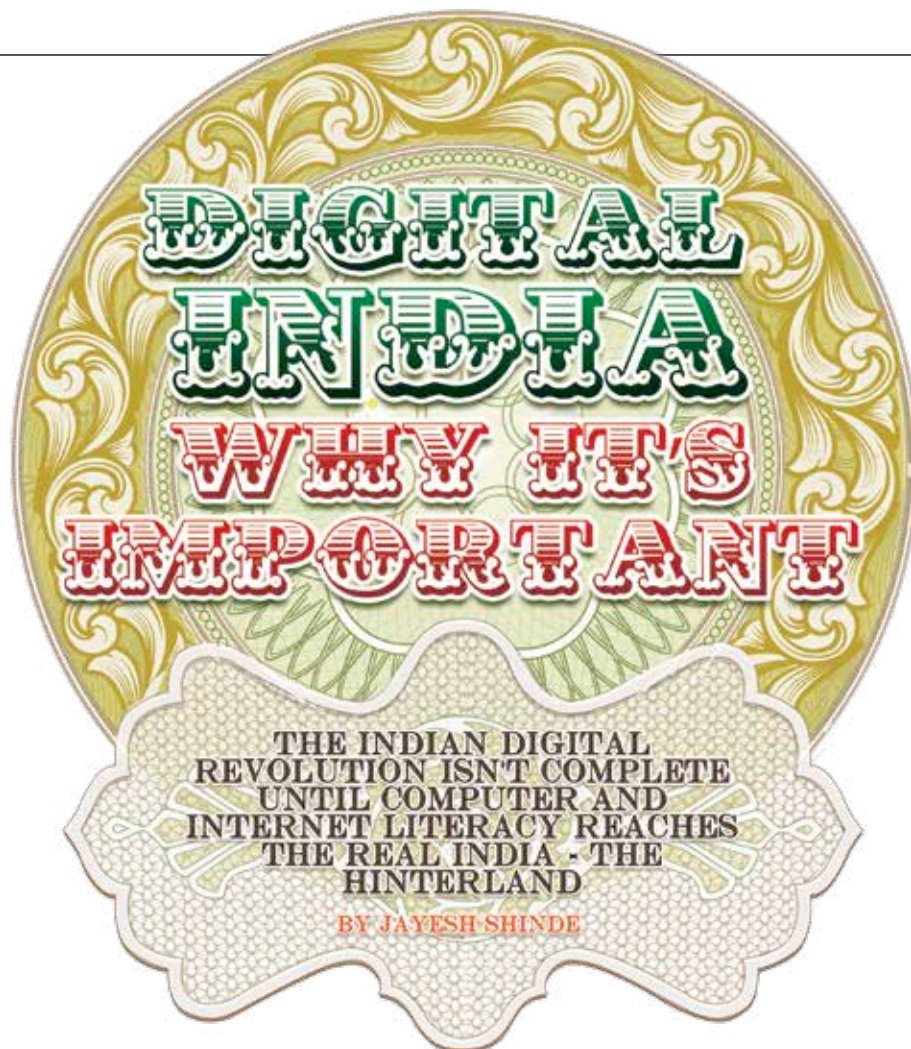




There is no doubt that when future humans look back upon this era, they will regard the 21st century as the first true Digital Century in the history of mankind. For all our efforts of mechanisation and digitisation, the personal computer revolution that began in the 1970s and '80s was the true catalyst to an explosion of digital initiatives that spanned from the Internet to thumb PCs and everything in between. Needless to say, we have been busy, us humans trying to outdo and out-innovate each other in this great digital rat race. And the mad rush refuses to slow down, as future economies will be decided by a nation's digital innovation and prowess. This is where an effort like Digital India becomes extremely critical both for Make in India's and your own personal success.

Technology is the great leveller of our times, and its transformative power needs to be felt by each and every citizen of this country. This is crucial if it's going to have any chance of progressing

to a radical new level and keep pace with other fast-advancing nations of the world. The government can't just flag-off the race and be a mute spectator in this endeavour. It needs to show more than mere intent. Steps must be taken to cultivate favourable conditions to ensure the Digital India dream is well and truly realized. Here's what needs to happen, and happen quickly, as far as removing roadblocks is concerned:

TRUE BROADBAND

If there's one resounding fact about our country's Internet connection that makes us pull our hair out in frustration, it's the disappointingly slow data speeds. Upgrading from the 56.6 Kbps dial up era in the late '90s / early 2000s to 128 & 256 Kbps "broadband" cable Internet in mid-2000s felt amazing; and taking the leap to 1 or 2 "Mbps" in the 2010s almost had us in throes of digital orgasm! We felt we had arrived on the big stage, harboured dreams of finally being able to download the whole Internet even. Oh the naivety of it all!

According to Ookla Speedtest's Net Index (<http://www.netindex.com/download/allcountries>), India ranks at 129 out of 198 countries in the world. Where the global download and upload average stands at 24.4Mbps and 11.2Mbps, respectively, the same for India averages at 7.6Mbps and 5.3Mbps, respectively. Not a pretty picture that, is it? It gets worse.

Akamai's State of the Internet report (<http://www.stateoftheinternet.com>) released earlier this year claims the average Indian Internet speed to be at a paltry 2.3Mbps, which is less than half of the global average Internet speed of 5Mbps. Clearly, the status quo needs to change drastically if there's going to be any hope towards dragging India's fortunes from the dark age of digital infancy and transforming it into a digital powerhouse. The first step towards correcting this disparity starts at the government's door.

We've said this before and we'll say this again. TRAI needs to redefine what qualifies as "broadband" Internet speeds in the country, if we are to have any chance